Problem 5: Bahinemo

Here are the first ten multiples of a number less than 10 written in Bahinemo[4] in ascending order:

(a) həl baɸú həl ɸənbí husí

(b) həl baɸú həl baɸú wá ɸənbí gədà

(c) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ dəbátʰà

(d) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ yemú həl baɸú həl ɸənbí huməlí

(e) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ yemú həl baɸú həl baɸú wá baɸú

(f) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ husí husí

(g) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ husí həl baɸú həl ɸənbí gədà

(h) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ husí həl baɸú həl baɸú wá baɸú wá ɸənbí dəbátʰà

(i) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ huməlí huməlí

(j) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ huməlí həl baɸú həl baɸú

Bahinemo speakers often use a shortened form for some numbers. This, however, can lead to some ambiguity: a Bahinemo numeral in its shortened form can be interpreted as two different numbers.

Assignment 1: (4 marks)

Exactly one of the numbers given above is in its shortened form. All the other numbers are in the long form. In this case, the shortened numeral has only one interpretation, so there is no ambiguity. Which number is this, and what is its Hindu-Arabic equivalent? What is its Bahinemo long form? How is the shorthand form of a numeral derived from the long form?

Assignment 2: (8 marks)

Give all possible translations of the following Bahinemo numerals to Hindu-Arabic numbers. Some of these numerals may be in an ambiguous shortened form.

(a) ímà tʰú hwəsə́

(b) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ həl baɸú həl ɸənbí huməlí

(c) həl baɸú həl ɸənbí gədà

(d) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ həl baɸú həl baɸú həl baɸú həl baɸú wá ɸənbí husí

(e) ímà tʰú hwəsə́ həl baɸú

[4]Bahinemo is a Sepik language spoken in East Sepik Province, Papua-New Guinea. It is spoken in 4 villages, including in Gahom village of Tunap-Hunstein Rural LLG in East Sepik Province. Traditionally, Bahinemo speaking people rarely used large numbers in their daily life. Numbers above one hundred could in theory be correctly spoken, but the resulting phrase is so long and convoluted that hearers in the 1970s puzzled over them.

Assignment 3: (8 marks)

Translate the following Hindu-Arabic numerals to Bahinemo. When possible, give both the shorthand and the long form of the numbers in Bahinemo.

(a) 17

(b) 29

(c) 81

(d) 180

(e) 23

– Aparna Gupte